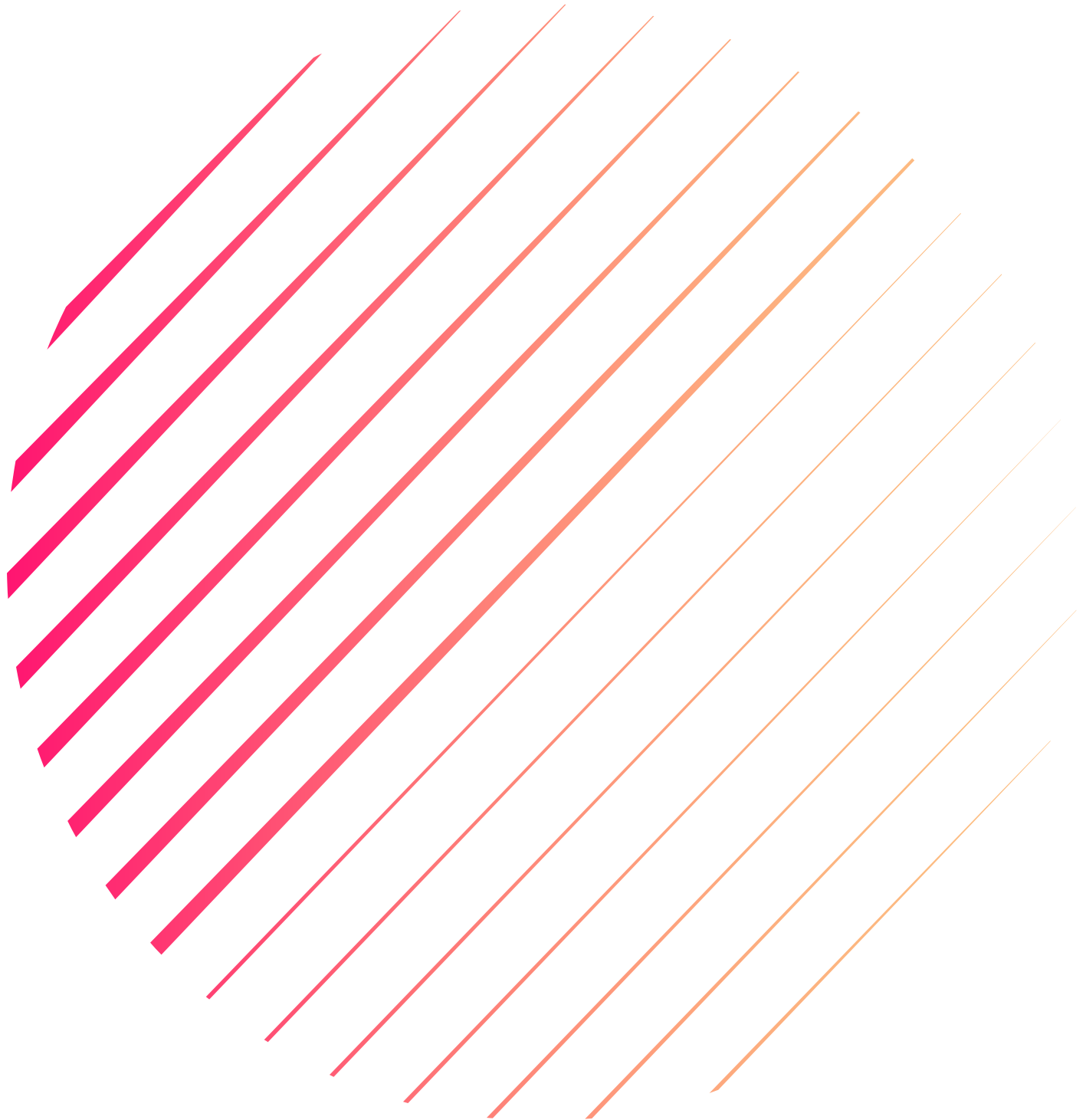




BUCKINGHAMSHIRE
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Buissness of VideoGames

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Introduction

In an era dominated by surface-level interactions and instant gratification, the need for deeper self-reflection and philosophical exploration is increasingly urgent (Gibson, 2024). This project explores how video games can engage players with life's "big questions", identity, morality, free will, strength, and virtue. Inspired by a personal experience that reshaped my understanding of a fulfilling life, this game aims to encourage introspection and critical thought through immersive gameplay, helping players develop greater self-awareness and compassion. By promoting empathy and restraint, the game seeks to foster a kinder, more virtuous society (Fletcher, 2020).

At its core lies the philosophy that true strength is not the capacity to harm, but the conscious decision to refrain. The central dilemma invites players to consider whether they can choose empathy and restraint when they have the power to do otherwise.

Identifying and Exploring Philosophical Themes

Games like *Bioshock Infinite*, *Spec Ops: The Line*, and *Detroit: Become Human* have introduced moral dilemmas, yet they often stop at surface-level engagement (Schubert, 2018). Project Ouroboros aims to go deeper, asking players to confront their internal moral compass and reflect on their identity, strength, and personal ethics beyond immediate consequences.

Rather than presenting morality as a binary, the game challenges players with layered ethical decisions and nuanced power dynamics. The goal is not to enforce moral lessons but to invite players to explore what strength, virtue, and free will truly mean to them.

Game Title & Overview

Project Ouroboros is a narrative-driven, choice-based game set in the world of Kairon, a fragmented, surreal realm suspended in a decaying time loop. One moment you're walking through a city frozen in eternal sunset; the next, a desert blooms and dies around you. Time doesn't flow in Kairon, it folds. Players take on the role of a protagonist gaining control over time and space, caught in a loop where each decision reshapes reality. Inspired by the Ouroboros, a symbol of self-destruction and rebirth, players must navigate a collapsing world and decide how to use their growing power.

The core question: *What will you do when you can do anything?* Each loop iteration deepens the philosophical and moral engagement.

Core Concept & Objectives

Project Ouroboros is an exploration of strength, morality, and free will. Players inhabit Riven, a quiet, scarred survivor altered by exposure to time anomalies. As they traverse fractured cities like Elystra or surreal realms like the Inner Loop, they meet characters such as the Man in the Suit, a composed

and enigmatic figure who speaks in riddles and seems to know Riven intimately. Player choices, whether to show mercy or manipulate, affect these characters' behaviours. An ally may become distant, hostile, or enlightened depending on your actions.

The environments shift in parallel. Skies fracture, buildings warp, or Solvyr, a luminous dragon of light, might appear when restraint is shown. There's no conventional "win." Success is measured by the player's internal evolution, how others react, how the world reshapes, and whether the cycle of harm can truly be broken.

Key Mechanics & Gameplay Loop

1. Time Manipulation: Players can slow, accelerate, or rewind events. This mechanic reinforces themes of determinism versus agency and invites players to rethink outcomes.
2. Combat and Stealth: Combat is possible but destabilises the world. Stealth rewards patience and ethical restraint.
3. Dialogue and Philosophical Choices: NPC interactions present complex moral dilemmas. Outcomes are shaped not only by choice but by intention.
4. Puzzle Solving: Environmental puzzles symbolise internal growth. Solutions change based on prior decisions and shape the player's relationship with the world.

Sample Story Moment

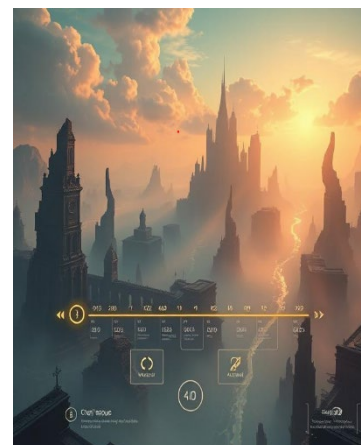
In Elystra, a city locked in perpetual golden hour, a woman insists her daughter never existed. Later, you uncover a hidden memory, her daughter was erased from the timeline when Riven chose to save someone else. You can restore the girl, undoing another's survival; convince the mother her memory is false; or simply walk away. No option is without consequence. Every choice echoes into future loops.

World Interaction & Exploration

Open hub areas, each with distinct aesthetics, challenges, and characters. Players are free to explore, uncover truths, and engage with the metaphysical structure of the world. Subtle player actions affect environmental details—light shifts, time distortions, NPC responses.

The core loop revolves around choice and reflection. Players revisit key moments with new knowledge, testing whether fate is fixed or flexible. Replayability emerges not from branching dialogue trees, but from the emotional and metaphysical consequences of prior loops.

Each cycle doesn't just remember—it reshapes what's possible. *(Right, UI)*



Target Audience & Platform

Project Ouroboros targets players who crave deep, narrative-rich experiences and philosophical engagement. Fans of *The Last of Us*, *Outer Wilds*, and *Hellblade* will connect with its emotional and narrative ambition.

The game is intended for PEGI 18+ due to mature themes, violence, strong language, and moments of existential introspection that may be emotionally challenging. It will release on PS5, Xbox Series X/S, and PC, with a potential VR version to deepen the metaphysical immersion.

Art Style & Environment Design

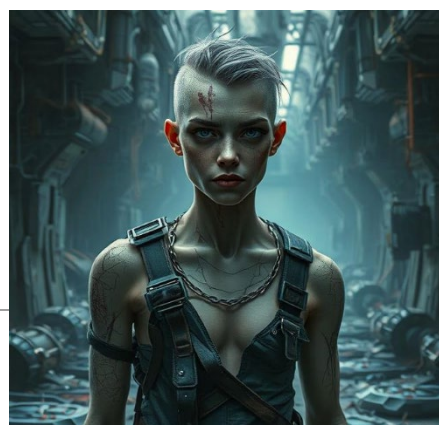
Photorealistic with stylised surreal overlays, echoing dream logic and philosophical symbolism.

Worlds will reflect choices—shifting between beauty and decay based on the player's path.

- The Citadel of Hands: A towering, broken structure with mechanical arms that hold fractured memories.
- Elystra: Utopian and decaying all at once, its sun never sets, and its water flows backwards.
- The Inner Loop: A realm of glass, ink, and shifting metaphysical constructs—symbolising memory, identity, and possibility.

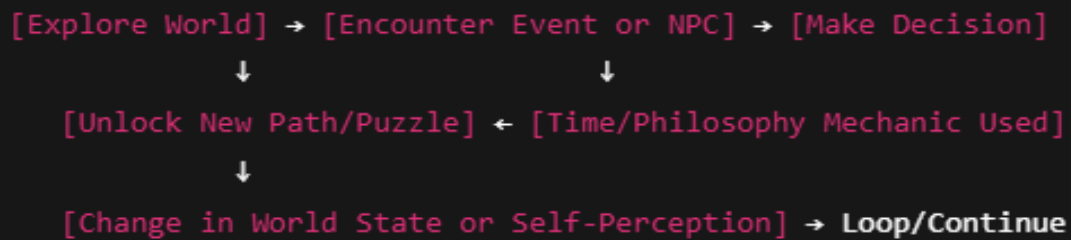
Multidimensional areas will defy logic, aligning with the metaphysical themes of time, fate, and rebirth.

Referenced Below (1-3 Upper left to right) (4-6 Lower Left to Right)



- Not just a narrative game—a reflective experience where gameplay becomes personal philosophy.
- The world changes not just from what you do, but how you do it.
- Time manipulation isn't a gimmick; it's a lens to examine consequence.
- Solvyr, the light dragon, appears only in moments of genuine restraint or clarity—rewarding empathy not with points, but presence.

Can you choose restraint when power is easier? Or is power the right choice in this instance?



Marketing Strategy and Production Roadmap

Cinematic trailers, interactive teasers, and philosophical content to engage emotionally invested audiences. Social media, influencer partnerships, and showcases (e.g., E3) will spread awareness. Community discussions on moral choice and game design will drive deeper engagement.

Development Timeline:

- Months 1–4: Narrative planning, art language, vertical slice prototype.
 - Month 5: Functional game loop and core systems.
 - Months 6–12: Iterative development and testing with feedback integration.
 - Months 13–24: Full production, final art pass, polish, and marketing rollout.
 - Launch Goal: End of year two.
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Conclusion

Project Ouroboros is not just a game. It's a philosophical journey disguised as a story. Through mechanics that mirror moral struggle and a world that reflects the player's inner shifts, it invites players to do more than act, it asks them to reflect.

By blending dynamic gameplay with deep moral questions, the game challenges the player to look inward. To ask not just *what* they can do, but *who* they become by doing it.

In a looped world where everything changes, the only way forward might be the hardest path: compassion.

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Referencing

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Gibson, E.D., 2024b. A philosophical exploration of instant gratification and instant pain relief. Medium, 27 November. Available at: <https://deonch30.medium.com/a-philosophical-exploration-of-instant-gratification-and-instant-pain-relief-9f84e3ae77cf> [Accessed 6 May 2025].

Schubert, S., 2018. Dystopia in the Skies: negotiating justice and morality on screen in the video game BioShock Infinite. *European Journal of American Studies*, (13-4). <https://doi.org/10.4000/ejas.14089>

AI Prompts

The Citadel of Hands

A brutalist megastructure rising into the sky, made of concrete and steel, with massive mechanical hands reaching out from the architecture. Floating shards of memory suspended in the air, glowing slightly. Cloudy, ominous sky. Post-human dystopia meets metaphysical dreamscape.

The Inner Loop Realm

“An abstract, ink-and-glass dimension with floating platforms, glowing symbols, and transparent memory structures. The space feels alive—walls pulse, and the floor distorts with each step. No clear physics. Everything is dreamlike and shifting. Riven stands at the edge, looking into endless refracted timelines.”

Elystra –The Golden City

“A city frozen in eternal golden hour, skyscrapers with cracked glass reflecting a warped sun. Streets shifting with time distortions—some frozen mid-collapse, others reversed. A canal with flowing water running backward. Architecture blends utopian futurism and ancient ruin. Surreal, melancholic beauty.”

Time Fracture Moment

“A dramatic scene where time fractures around Riven—objects frozen mid-air, clocks melting, NPCs glitching. The sky above splits into fragments like broken glass. Light bends unnaturally, and colour drains from the environment. Surreal, high drama, symbolism-heavy sci-fi.”

Riven (Main Character)

“A scarred, androgynous character standing alone in a ruined futuristic facility. Subtle glowing lines across their skin, wearing tattered yet high-tech clothing. Surrounded by broken time-manipulation devices. Stoic expression, eyes reflecting fractured timelines. Moody lighting, cinematic, surreal sci-fi setting.”

The Man in the Suit

“A sharply dressed man in a black-and-white glitching suit, half his face blurred like a corrupted video file. Standing in front of a mirror that doesn't reflect him correctly. Dimly lit hallway, abstract clockwork and fragmented reality around him. Sinister elegance, timeless atmosphere, unsettling calm.”